

CHAPTER 2

The Katyuri Dynasty & Parmar Dynasty of Garhwal

PART A: THE KARTIKEYAPUR (KATYURI) DYNASTY (700 CE – 11th Century)

The Kartikeyapur Dynasty, commonly known as the Katyuri Dynasty, holds the distinction of being the first unified historical dynasty of Uttarakhand. Their reign is widely regarded as the Golden Age of the region's architecture and sculpture.

2.1 FOUNDATION & KEY RULERS

The dynasty was founded by Basant Dev around 700 CE. The rulers adopted the imperial title of *Paramabhataraka Maharajadhiraja Parameshwar*, reflecting their claim to supreme sovereignty over the region. Their first capital was established at Joshimath in Chamoli district, which was later shifted to Vaidhnath-Kartikeyapur in the Katyur Valley near Baijnath by Subhikshraj Dev (though folk ballads attribute this move to Narsingh Dev).

Three rulers stand out as particularly consequential. Ishtagan of the Nimbar Dynasty was the first to unite the entire Uttarakhand region into a single political entity; he was a Shaivite ruler and the true unifier of the land. Lalitsur Dev was the most powerful ruler and a prolific builder — the maximum number of copper plate inscriptions belong to his reign, and he was described in these plates as a *Varaha* (boar) incarnation who uplifted the earth. Bhudev was a staunch supporter of Brahmanism who opposed Buddhism and contributed heavily to the construction of the Baijnath temple.

2.2 ADMINISTRATION & MILITARY STRUCTURE

Territorial Division

The Katyuri administrative system was highly centralized and hierarchical. At the apex stood the King, beneath whom the territory was divided into Bhuktis (provinces) headed by an Uparika. Each Bhukti was subdivided into Vishs (districts) managed by a Vishpati, which in turn contained Pallikas (villages) headed by a Mahattam or Sayan.

Key Administrative Officials

The state employed a specialized bureaucracy. The Saudabhangadhikrit served as the Chief Architect for state construction projects. Border security was managed by the Prantpal (protector of state borders) and Ghattapal (protector of mountain passes). The Narapati managed river ghats and collected crossing taxes. Financial accountability fell to the Akshapatlik (Chief Auditor) and Bhogpati (tax collector). The Bhatt and Char officials were responsible for extracting begar (forced labour), while the Pramavatar or Prabhatar served as the land measurement officer.

Military Divisions

The Katyuri military was organized into four divisions: Infantry commanded by the Gaulmika, Cavalry under the Ashvabaladhikrit, an Elephant Corps led by the Hastibaladhikrit, and a Camel Corps under the Ushtrabaladhikrit.

2.3 ECONOMY & TAXATION

Agriculture, minerals, and forests constituted the primary revenue sources of the Katyuri state. Land measurement followed a standardized system in which the basic units were the Dronavapam and Nali Vapam. Larger measurements included the Kulyavap (equivalent to 8 Dron) and the Kharivap (equivalent to 20 Dron).

The Katyuri military was organized into four divisions: Infantry commanded by the Gaulmika, Cavalry under the Ashvabaladhikrit, an Elephant Corps led by the Hastibaladhikrit, and a Camel Corps under the Ushtrabaladhikrit.

2.3 ECONOMY & TAXATION

Agriculture, minerals, and forests constituted the primary revenue sources of the Katyuri state. Land measurement followed a standardized system in which the basic units were the Dronavapam and Nali Vapam. Larger measurements included the Kulyavap (equivalent to 8 Dron) and the Kharivap (equivalent to 20 Dron).

The dynasty maintained a system of land grants known as Vishnupriti, Goonth, or Agrahar — tax-free lands donated to Brahmins or temples. This Goonth land grant system formed the foundation of the temple economy in ancient Uttarakhand and enabled the construction and maintenance of the region's remarkable sacred architecture.

2.4 SOCIETY, CULTURE & RELIGION

Sanskrit served as the court language, while the common people spoke Prakrit or Pali (Lokbhasha). The most significant religious event of this period was the arrival of Adi Guru Shankaracharya, who established Jyotirmath (Badrikashram) as part of his mission to re-establish Hinduism across the subcontinent. Shankaracharya is believed to have renounced his body at Kedarnath in 820 CE.

2.5 ARCHITECTURE — THE ZENITH OF TEMPLE CONSTRUCTION

The Katyuri period represents the architectural Golden Age of Uttarakhand, heavily influenced by the Nagara style of North Indian temple architecture. Two distinct styles emerged during this era.

The Chhatra-Type (Pagoda) style featured a distinctive wooden umbrella (*chhatra*) roof and was predominantly wood-based. Notable examples include the Kedarnath Temple, Lakhamandal, and the temples at Bageshwar. The Shikhara-Type was characterized by square, stone-built structures without wooden umbrellas, often constructed in family groups. Outstanding examples include the Dwarahat Group (Gujar Deval) and the Katarmal Sun Temple.

Among the key architectural sites, Jageshwar contains over 100 temples showcasing both Nagara and Shikara styles. Dwarahat (Gujar Deval) stands as an incomparable example of the Shikhara style. The Katarmal Sun Temple holds the distinction of being the second largest Sun Temple in India. Baijnath features the main Shiva shrine accompanied by 17 subsidiary shrines.

2.6 DECLINE & FRAGMENTATION

The decline of the Katyuri Dynasty was driven by multiple factors. Weak successors allowed internal administrative decay to set in. Two devastating Nepalese invasions accelerated the collapse: King Ashokchalla attacked in 1191 CE, and King Krachaldeva subjugated Katyuri and early Chand territories in 1223 CE. The dynasty eventually fractured into multiple branches, including the Rajwars of Askot and the Mallas of Doti. The last ruler, Brahmadev (also known as Veerdev), was highly tyrannical and oppressive — according to the folk ballad *Jiyarani*, his misrule was the primary internal cause of the dynasty's collapse. The rising Chand Dynasty eventually ended Katyuri supremacy entirely.

2.7 COPPER PLATE EVIDENCE

Copper plate inscriptions discovered at various locations provide crucial historical evidence of the Katyuri Dynasty. Plates found at Pandukeshwar document Lalit Sur Dev's rule and land grants. Those at Bageshwar, issued by King Bhudev, name eight Katyuri kings. Additional plates from Kandara provide administrative evidence, while those found at Champawat confirm the dynasty's presence in Kumaon.